Let GOODFELLOWSHIP prevail in the Greatest Sport on Earth - Motorcycling™

The Spokesman

Official Newsletter of the Badger Heritage Chapter
Antique Motorcycle Club of America

Summer - June 8, 2026

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Cover Photo by Steve Peters

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Presidents Message

Jon D. Oeflein - President



Hello Badgers!

Summer is finally here and the riding season in the midwest is upon us! I want to highlight the many events coming down the pike, but first a few words about our just past Spring Meeting. I think I can sum this one up with a big smile! The weather turned out perfect and attendance was strong. Frank and Patti Rick had their place all ready for us. Their home is really cool and used to be the clubhouse of a golf course. After much work they have transformed it into a comfortable place with a great shop for their motorcycle passion.

If you weren't able to make the meeting, you missed a great meal. The food came from Altona Super Club and was delicious. As for the heavy lifting of the day, I think it went well. I tried my best to shepherd us through the many topics that needed discussion in a timely manner. We covered a lot of ground and all the important questions were answered. Another successful Spring Meeting is in the books. It was great to see so many vintage bikes out of hibernation and on the road. I want to thank the Ricks, Rich Hinderholtz and the officers/advisors who all helped make the meeting a success.

Now let's chat about our summer. By the time you receive this publication we will have already had our tent up at the Milwaukee Cycle Swap which is always at the Bad Moon Saloon. This is Steve Schwoegler's baby and is always a good time. Then we start a really busy stretch. Chris Gunn's Beer City Show is the 13th at Puddler's Hall. This event has been growing every year and many Badgers attend. I will, once again, have our tent up. We will be stocked with cold beverages so stop by and have one between beers.

The very next day is the Pokey Run. This year's run is taking place much earlier than past years. Steve decided to actually push the publication of this Spokesman up a week so you would have the event poster beforehand. So fire up your crazy, wacky, little bike that sits in the corner most of the time and join the fun!

Next we have Tom Hinderholtz's 90th Knucklehead Anniversary fest starting on the 16th.You can still sign up for this and you don't need a knucklehead to be a part of the fun! Of course, the knuckle riders will be featured as this is a big anniversary for the model that my family produced from 1936 to 1947. It is a very special bike to me as it is the last model that my great-grandfather Walter brought to market. Tommy is letting AMCA members sign up right until the 16th, so get to antiquemotorcycle.org and grab a spot. You don't want to miss this historic event!

Knuckle fest ends at the Wild Ones rally at the H-D Museum on the 20th. Please try to come by and support our friends at the Museum. Yes we lost the ability to host our field games (something that still pisses me off) but it is still a good time. This year, Kevin Hannaman is hosting an Antiques vs Choppers Kickstart Competition! Yes you read that correctly! I need 10 members to challenge the chopper guys. I am totally jazzed about this and WE HAVE TO WIN! This goes down at 1pm and is for big twins only. If YOU would like to be on our team, please let me know asap.

We have one more event in June. This one is a ride that Carlos Rodriguez is putting on in memory of his dad, Bill. Many of us were friends with Bill and I am sure that the memory of Milwaukee Mike will be included in this celebration as well. The ride starts from the south side of Milwaukee on the 26th. I will send out all the details as they become available. All Badgers are welcome to attend. I will be there!

This brings us to July. First up is Kevin Hannaman's Stoopid Chopper Show on the 11th and also at the Bad Moon Saloon. I have had our tent up for the last two years and plan to again. This show is all about choppers, but the parking lot is for vintage and a good time is had by all. The following Saturday is something I have been working on with H-D and the Davidson Park Foundation. It is called Bikes, Bourbon and BBQ. How is that for a combination! I have negotiated a sweet deal for our chapter. Anyone who brings a vintage bike to Davidson Park on the 18th, from 3-6pm, will get a t-shirt, lunch, swag and free bourbon samples! How fun is this going to be! I will have an invite out soon. I am hoping for 75 bikes.

Our final event in July is up in Green Bay. For the first time ever, the AMCA has teamed up with the Antique Automobile Club of America to create this car and bike show. Support our National and attend this first year collaboration This is an opportunity to get your bike judged right here in Wisco. More information can be found on the AMCA website and I will be sending more too.

Now for August. The 15th is our Summer Party at Wade and Drex's farm. This is a one day event that is going to be a blast! We are planning a big catered lunch, a DJ and swag for all who RSVP. This is going to be a free event, but only to those who let us know they are coming and if they are bringing a guest. This can be done by emailing us at badgersamca@gmail.com. Our only other event in August is one that is sure to have a huge turn out. This is Milwaukee Mike's celebration of life. I will be there as well as many other members. I will be posting details about this day and many others will too. Ride in Peace Mikey.

The season ends with Jim Feyereisen's 33 Ride. This fun time is reserved for those with vintage trikes or side car rigs. It is three days of riding on three wheels. Jim always puts his heart into these specialty events and I am sure the routes and fun will not disappoint.

That is the 2026 line up for the MOST ACTIVE CHAPTER IN THE AMCA!

Hope to see you soon,
Your pres,

Jono

Badger Heritage Chapter

SUMMER PICNIC

Saturday, August 15, 2026 - Noon

LIVE DJ - CATERED LUNCH
PRIZES - MEMORIAL SWAG
FREE TO ALL MEMBERS THAT RSVP



Wade and Drex's Farm
W8549 Well Lane, Lowell, Wis. 53579
(414) 315-8644
RSVP required to badgersamca@gmail.com or FB invite

Vice Presidents Message

Chris Tribbey - Vice President



Greetings from your VP,

Wow! June is here with the snap of the fingers – before you know it Labor Day will be here. June begins with a full calendar of events, and it continues through the rest of the summer. The time is here that we all have been waiting for – time to RIDE!

In May I attended the AMCA European Meet: swap meet and bike judging. Think Wauseon only at a much smaller level. There were about 50 vendors each displaying and selling JD, VL, WL, and Indian parts for the most part. Some Knucklehead, Panhead, and Shovelhead parts were available, but mostly the previous mentioned model families.

I met fellow Badger Ed Lamb over there which was really nice. Also enjoyed the comradery these events present to us. I enjoyed talking to friends from Switzerland, Holland, Germany, and England. The antique motorcycle language is truly global.

As most of you I have been busy getting my bikes out of winter storage, and ready to ride. Tasks included air pressure checks, installing the batteries that have been kept on tenders all winter, changing oil and filters, cleaning and lubing chains and cables, and a nice cleaning. One biggie is I also transferred my "caretaker" status of my 1960 FLH to the next caretaker. The caretaker is a fellow Badger, so you will still see the bike, however the new owner is in the process of making it "their own". I am thrilled to have the bike with this guy.

I'm looking forward to vending at the June 6th swap meet and participating in the 90th Knucklehead Anniversary, Wild One day, and the Beer City Bike show. All of this in June. Hope to see many of you also enjoying these awesome gatherings.

See you down the road!

Chris Tribbey
VP, Badger Heritage

Notes From the Secretary

Danielle Werner - Chapter Secretary



Badger Heritage Spring Meeting 5/30/2026

Introductions

Tribute to members who've passed. Laura Burke is in hospital. Al Feirheisen spoke about Greg Pegal. Jon Davidson spoke about Mike Beine (Wrench), Chris Tribe spoke about Milwaukee Mike.

No new members preset but we do have a few new members since last meeting.

Boz Treasure's Report reminder membership is important, dues pay for events like this. We now have 2 & 3 year option. Still have 88 members who need to pay dues. We are strong financially. 294 members currently.

Tribey VP updates. National – will be adding an additional director on Board of Directors, they want it to be a President of one of the Chapters. Swap Met season is underway.

Social Media update – members only FB page is the best place to get all info on Badgers.

Old business - we had presence at Mama Tried, had excellent attendance at Winter Luncheon.

Frank Rick thanked the caterer "The Altona" said if anyone breaks down in the area he will come pick them up.

New business – looking for someone to man the tent at Brewtown Rumble, Jon will be at Davidson Park. Schedule of events is on FB and Jon will email as well.

Come out to Wild Ones and Puddlers Hall to support younger guys. Kevin spoke about Stupid Chopper Ride there will be a kick start competion – idea to bridge gap between younger guys and Badgers (20th at 1:00).

Summer picnic will be a one day deal, no charge to members will be sometime in August.

Steve Peters merchandise update, presented framed poster to Frank Rick for hosting.

Danielle Werner
Chapter Secretary

In Memoriam
Badger Gregory David Pagel - 5/17/53 - 2/10/26



Gregory David Pagel, age 72, passed away peacefully at home surrounded by his family on February 10, 2026, after a brave nine-month battle with pancreatic cancer. Gregory was born on May 17, 1953, in Athens, Georgia to the late Kenneth Pagel Sr. and Peggy (Griffeth) Amsler. Greg spent his whole life in Wisconsin.

Greg was a U.S. Air Force veteran, (1972-1976), achieving the rank of Staff Sergeant. He was an Aircraft Maintenance Specialist, working on Boeing B-52 heavy bombers at Carswell AFB, Texas. Greg also earned his GED while at Carswell.

After serving out his four-year enlistment with the Air Force, Greg had several careers over his lifetime, having worked for Harley-Davidson, and the U.S. Postal Service. Later on, he had his own independent motorcycle repair and sales shop (Rerun Motorcycles), in Sheboygan, for 14 years. He was an expert mechanic. His last job before retiring was as a special needs bus driver for Prigge Bus in Sheboygan.

On May 17, 2014, Greg married his angel, Wendy Kolb, and it was a very good match for both. Wendy shared Greg's love of motorcycling, riding together as often as they could. enjoying the great back roads that are found in Wisconsin. Greg also rode with his close friend Paul Lukes, having taken several multi-state rides over the years.

Greg and Wendy were active members of the Badger Chapter of the Antique Motorcycle Club of America, participating in many road runs and activities with the club. Over the years, Greg restored several vintage cycles, including a 1936 Harley-Davidson VL, a 1951 Triumph T100 "Tiger 500", and a rare Honda CB 750 "Sandcast", to name just a few.

Greg also enjoyed Karaoke nights at local pubs in Sheboygan, singing classics by Frank Sinatra, Dean Martin, and others. He and Wendy were also members of St. John-St. Peter Lutheran Church in Cleveland, Wisconsin.

Chapter Spring Meeting - New Holstein, WI - 5/30/26

Story and Photos by Steve Peters





The Spring Meeting was held at Frank and Patti Rick's place in New Holstein for the third time. Twice before we enjoyed their hospitality and Goodfellowship for our Fall Meeting in 2018 and the Spring Meeting in 2022.

The Weather was a little cool for a long ride, but was somewhat refreshing. The sun was out and it became actually comfortably warm as the meeting continued. There were about 60 in attendance with 42 motorcycles.

A full agenda for the year was presented to the members with plenty to do for those that enjoy old bikes including the off hand mention of a possible new ride - see my Newsletter Editor column.

The food was catered this time by the Altona Supper Club in New Holstein and was plentiful and quite delicious!

For me it was a two hour ride each way and as I mentioned in the previous Spokesman, my ass was hurting, but I had a great time nonetheless.

I'm sure I'll see many of you at more events this year!

Steve Peters





Chapter Spring Meeting - New Holstein, WI - 5/30/26

Photos by Steve Peters







Chapter Spring Meeting - New Holstein, WI - 5/30/26

Photos by Steve Peters







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Photos by Steve Peters







From the Desk of the Newsletter Editor

Sportster Anniversary Ride by Steve Peters





Hey Badgers!

While at the Spring Meeting I mentioned something off the cuff, that may actually become a reality.

Over the years there have been many rides and runs devoted to specific anniversaries or themed events for specific models of motorcycles or engine types, etc. There have been rides for Knuckleheads, three wheelers, small, slow bikes just to name a few, but not anything for what I ride, a Sportster.

Don't get me wrong, I'm not upset about this or resentful, I was really only making a joke, but it seems like at least one other club member took it seriously. I did ask for a show of hands from the group as to who had a Sporty and several did raise their hands, so this may be a real thing to pursue.

A couple days after the Spring Meeting, I received an e-mail from fellow Badger Steve Strohmeier that I believe he also sent to at least one other person mentioning my comment. His idea is about celebrating the 70th anniversary of the Sportster next year in 2027. We could include the model that lead up to the Sportster, the K Model.

If we follow the 35 year rule and keep all bikes on the ride to at least 35 years old, we could also have K Models and stretch the potential accepted years from 1952 to 1991. I also agree with Steve and the 35 year rule would be strictly enforced.

Concerning the Sportster, there is the unique situation about the Sportster, and if you include the K Model, the bike has been continuously produced sine 1952 - 74 years. The only H-D model to live that long.

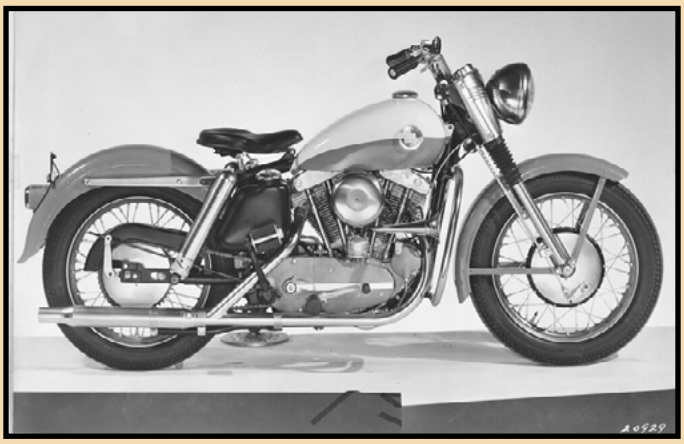
We will need more discussions and meetings, but the possibility to have the ride in the Kettle Moraine area has been mentioned with possible stops at some Harley-Davidson Motor Company locations in the area.

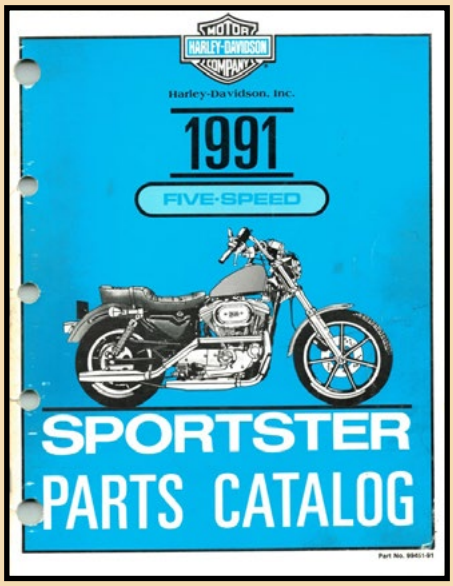
This is only the beginning of the project, but I am quite optimistic that it will be a great get together for those of us that ride the small twin that has lasted generations.

Take care and stay safe!

Steve Peters







Badger Heritage Chapter

8th ANNUAL

POKEY RUN

Sunday, June 14, 2026

9am (kickstands up at 10am)

Historical Wade House for a tour of the Carriage Museum

Lunch will be at Fudgie Knuckles in Glenbeulah

Scenic Northern Kettle Moraine Forest roadways

All bikes are welcome - larger rides leaving 30 minutes after the Pokeys depart



Antique Motorcycle Club of America
Badger Heritage Chapter

N1635 County Road GGG - Campbellsport, Wis. 53010

Jim Feyereisen - (920) 980-1161

Embracing the 35-year Rule: A 1990 Harley Electra Glide Sport

Story and Photos by Steve Strohmeier



Over the past decade, AMCA National Road Runs began to allow older riders to participate on modern, late model machinery. I have also seen this at our chapter meetings – members showing up on late model bikes. When I have spoken to AMCA members riding late model bikes at events, they generally say they are on a newer biker because they are worried about the reliability of their vintage bike or they are worried about damaging a prized antique.

While it is true you do not have to own or ride a vintage bike to be an AMCA or Badger member, I would like to encourage everyone to embrace the AMCA's 35-year rule and ride "new old bikes." This rule means any 1991 model year or older bike is fully eligible for all AMCA activities. And there are a lot of very inexpensive and very reliable 35 year old bikes out there waiting to find a new home.

With this in mind, I set out to see if I could easily put together a Harley Davidson AMCA road run machine for two people for less than $4,000 on the road with all maintenance, purchase price, tax, title, tags, and insurance for at least one year. I wanted a bike I could ride all day at 70-80 mph on the interstate with a passenger in perfect comfort. I wanted a bike I could use for commuting. Basically, I wanted a late 1980s touring bike.

Currently, pretty much all 1985 to 1991 Electra Glides are bargain basement bikes. There are many clean examples with low miles which can be bought for well under $4,000 and often $2,000 to $3,000. These bikes are not beat up bikes – they are often bikes that were loved for several seasons, then sat for several seasons. Most do need batteries and tires; but that is well within the skill set of AMCA members. The Evolution motor design will easily go 100,000 miles with basic oil changes and few parts are expensive for these models. All shop manuals, parts books, and wiring books are available for free download. Almost no special tools are needed to work on one of these bikes and the few that are needed are not expensive.

To illustrate, I purchased the pictured 1990 Harley Davidson Electra Glide Sport (FLHS) in October 2025. The FLHS was the base model in the FLT series from 1989 to 1992 -- it came without a full fairing, radio, or CB. The tourpak was optional. Otherwise, it is functionally identical to other Electra models that year. The FLHS morphed into today's Road King. It was a surprisingly popular model and one of the few new bikes Cycle World columnist Peter Egan bought for himself at the height of the "Harley Craze."

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Embracing the 35-year Rule: A 1990 Harley Electra Glide Sport

Story and Photos by Steve Strohmeier



I found this particular bike during my normal weekend scanning of Facebook Marketplace ads. This one was advertised at $3000 in Sheboygan. A quick back and forth with the seller told me why it was still for sale - the clutch had started to slip. The owner was waiting to have the clutch replaced so people could take the bike for test rides. I told him to not bother -- I'd take the bike as is for $2500. The owner seemed shocked someone would buy a bike without a test ride but agreed and we loaded the bike up after checking the title matched the frame.

After getting the bike home and on the lift; the cause of the slipping clutch became obvious. Both the cable adjustment and the pushrod adjustment were completely wrong. As a result, the clutch never really disengaged and was slowly eating itself at stops. While I was able to get the clutch functional for test riding; I replaced the clutch with a complete kit for less than $100. I bought a clutch compression tool for $20 and it made the job a snap. With the clutch buttoned up and the primary refilled, the bike fired right up.

So, what did we get -- well, we got a 56,000 mile bike that is about 95% stock. All replacement parts are genuine HD replacement parts. Biggest deviations are the Eagle Iron add ons for the primary inspection cover and the fuel tank filler, plus the later model mufflers. The few nicks and scratches in the paint polished right out. Mechanically, the only challenge was a sticking rear brake caliper. It took less than 20 minutes to rebuild the caliper and clean the corrosion that was causing the sticking. The tires, however, were beyond worn out and a fresh set of Shinko 777 touring tires were installed at each end along with a full repack and reseal of the wheel bearings.

All in all; the bike cost $2500 purchase; $311 for tax, title, and tags, $52 for a year of insurance, and $325 for tires/rear brakes/oil. That's just under $3200 all in to be on the road with fresh rubber. Over the past seven months, I put 2,000 miles on the bike in all-weather. At just over 57,000 miles the front exhaust lifter failed and I replaced all four tappets. The total repair bill was just over $200 for tappets and gaskets. So, even after 2,000 miles of riding; I am still below $3,500 all in. Josie and I are signed up for the Black Hills National Road Run and the Rocky Mountain Chapter's Invitational run this summer – so the FLHS will see quite a bit of use on AMCA events in 2026. For example, I rode it to our spring meeting at Frank and Patti Rick's place last month. It was 190 miles each way and the FLHS did not miss a beat.

Hopefully, the FLHS helps illustrate that you can buy a lot of bike for peanuts, keep it on the road for surprisingly little on-going investment, AND be fully AMCA compliant without having to ride a late model bike at events. I have a lot of different bikes and the FLHS has probably garnered the most comments from people of any bike I have had in the last 10 years. People constantly want to ask me about it, which is not something I expected from the newest bike in our collection.

Speedy Safely!

Steve Strohmeier



Across the Pond for Choppers: The Hook-Up Early Show

Story and Photos by Chris Gunns



When I told the guys from The Hook-Up, I'd be flying over for their Early Show just outside of Oxford, England, I'm pretty sure they thought I was pulling their leg. I met them the year before at Party at the Pen East, and we hit it off right away, the kind of instant chopper-brotherhood that doesn't need much more than a shared love of old iron and cold beer. But as the date got closer, the tickets got bought, the flight info got sent, and suddenly it was real. My wife and I were London-bound, with a train ticket waiting to carry us into Oxford.

This year marked the 10th and final running of the Early Show, put on by King James and his crew. Both Hook-Up shows, the Early Show and the main event in Wales come August, are calling it quits this year after a hell of a run. I'm already praying flights drop in price so I can get back over for the Wales finale too. But to be there for the last Early Show, held at Kingsly Cafe just outside Oxford, was something I won't soon forget. Hands down, this was the coolest motorcycle show I've ever been to.

A Sea of American Iron — On English Soil

More than 300 choppers rolled in, and the overwhelming majority were Harleys. I'd put it at 60% Shovelheads, Panheads, and Knuckleheads, which, as anyone who knows me knows, is my version of heaven. There's something surreal about seeing American bikes that far from home, ridden hard by folks who clearly love them as much as we do back in the States. Every one of these machines had been ridden in, not trailered, and you could feel that energy walking the grounds.

Standing Out as the Loud American

Leading up to the show, I'd been hammering social media and stuffed my bags with Beer City Cycles merch to hand out. The Hook-Up guys re-shared a lot of it, so between that, my tattoos, and being a loud-ass American, I stood out, but in the best possible way. People came up all day long to say hello, show me their bikes, share a beer, and swap stories. I'd hoped to get a chance to ride while I was over there, but it didn't come together this trip. Honestly though, between the conversations and the bikes, I never stopped moving. I was on the grounds for 11 hours and could've easily done 11 more.

Continued on next page







Across the Pond for Choppers: The Hook-Up Early Show

Story and Photos by Chris Gunns



Beer City Cycles Best of Show

I had the honor of handing out an award for my favorite bike of the show, and it went to Craig's Panhead chopper. Beautiful and crusty in all the right ways. I've got a serious soft spot for old bikes that have seen some miles, oil weeping from the cases, chipped paint, a zip tie or two holding something important together. That's a bike with a story.

Don't get me wrong, a clean shiny bike has its place too, and I got to be one of the first to lay eyes on Chris Hatton's Japanese-inspired Shovelhead chopper — the Born Free People's Champ builder's latest. Photos do not do that bike justice. In person, it's something else entirely.

Vendors, Contests, and One Brutal Beer

The Hook-Up crew put on a full day. There were vendors, food, "cold" beer (we'll let the English slide on that one), tattoos being laid down on-site, a kickstart contest, and a beer drinking contest. I'm proud to report your American boy brought home the title in the beer drink, though I'll say the contraption they strapped to me to drink out of might be the most ridiculous, difficult way I've ever consumed a beer in my life. Worth it.

Friends for Life, and What Comes Next

This show has me fired up for summer. I'm going to do everything I can to make it back over for the Wales show in August, the final Hook-Up event ever, and one I do not want to miss. With both shows closing the book this year, I've already got my eye on chopper shows in Berlin, Paris, and Switzerland for the years ahead. The friends I made on this trip are friends for life, and the memories from those 11 hours at Kingsly Cafe will ride with me for a long, long time.

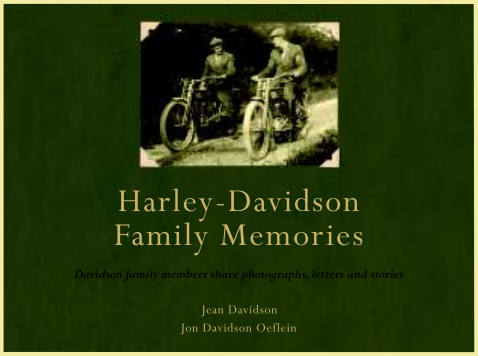
Big thanks to King James, the entire Hook-Up crew, and every single person who came up to shake my hand. Ten years is a hell of a run, and what a way to start closing it out.

Long live the chopper.
Chris Gunns









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In Memoriam
Badger Mikey "Milwaukee Mike" Johnston - 8/14/68 - 5/11/26



Milwaukee Mike Johnston left this world far too soon and unexpectedly on the morning of May 11, 2026. Michael Aaron Johnston was born in La Crosse, Wisconsin, on August 14, 1968, to Robert and Barbara Johnston. He proudly owned and operated PM Sign and Lighting for many years.

From a young age, Mike loved the outdoors, especially hunting — a devotion that remained constant throughout his life. When hunting season arrived, everything else could wait. He especially cherished the time spent hunting alongside his father, brother Steve, nephew Brenton, and close friends.

Cooking — whether spit-roasting chickens or tending a whole hog — was another of Mike's favorite pastimes.

Mike's greatest passion was the motorcycle world — the bikes, the people, and the camaraderie. He loved riding and sharing that enthusiasm with others. He served as a staff writer for Cycle Source Magazine, made annual trips to Sturgis, loved Harley-Davidson, enjoyed swap meets, and embraced all things Milwaukee. No matter where life took him, he always made time to visit family and friends along the way.

Mike was a kind and gentle giant who fiercely protected and cared for the people he loved. When you met Mike, you had a friend for life. He never met a stranger and was always willing to lend a hand to anyone in need. His bright smile, contagious personality, and unmistakable high-pitched laugh while watching movies will be deeply missed by all who knew him.

A celebration of Mikey's life will be held at what Mikey referred to as, "The Shop" —the place where he worked the hardest and welcomed so many of us over the last few years. Please join us at 2704 E. Norwich Avenue in St. Francis on Saturday, August 29, at 2 PM as we share stories, memories, and the love he left behind.

The Beginning: The Army Modernizes

Story by Matt Miller



Let me introduce myself, my name is Matt Miller, some may know me as Military Matt. I've been a Badger member on and off for about 23 years now. I own a 1943 Harley-Davidson WLA and a 1940 BSA M20 motorcycle. I would like to share some of my knowledge on the partnership between Harley-Davidson and the military through World War Two.

I hope to achieve this through multiple chapters as time goes on. Subjects to include are a brief history of H-D use by the military, Schools given by H-D, specialized tools used by the military, and manufacturers that supported Harley-Davidson during the war. Also, then and now photos of various sites during the war. It will be a journey that I hope you enjoy and may be of some interest.

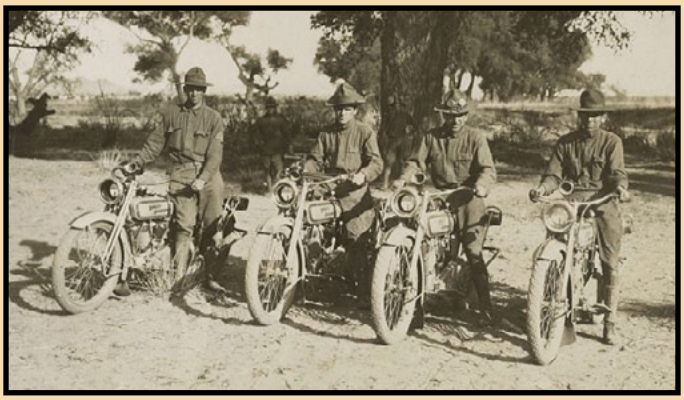
The Beginning: The Army Modernizes



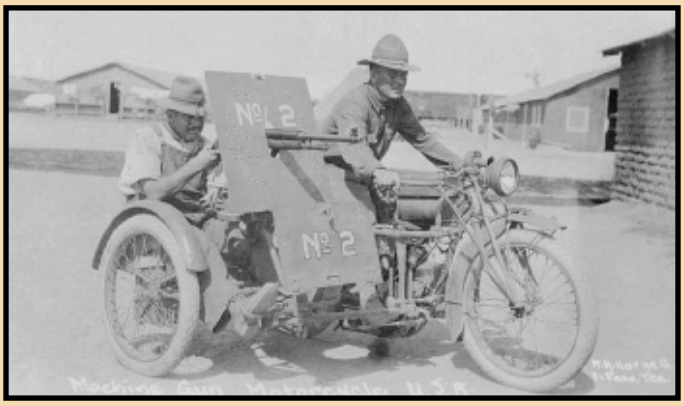
With the advent of the motorcycle, the Army began testing the practical use of them as far back as 1913.

After the Raid on March 9, 1916 of Columbus New Mexico by Poncho Villa and his revolutionaries; then Commanding General Black Jack Pershing and 10,000 troops were dispatched to capture these Mexican bandits. General Pershing recognized the need for versatile and reliable transportation during the expedition in the rugged terrain of Northern Mexico and requested the war department to purchase 12 motorcycles with more to come. This would be the first use of motorcycles being used in combat. Many of the bikes were used for scouting, communication, and rapid deployment.

Although the expedition failed to capture Villa, the performance of the motorcycles was considered a success, cementing a lasting partnership between the military and Harley-Davidson.



The Army primarily used the Harley-Davidson J -model, 61 cubic inch model capable of doing 60mph.





A possible precursor to the tank?

Continued on the next page

The Beginning: The Army Modernizes

Story by Matt Miller



Photo below-
Interesting to note Poncho Villa was a motorcycle rider, yet rumor had it that he preferred Indian cycles. It was also rumored he used one during his exploits into the US during his raids. Indian and H-D faced off not only on the track but also the battlefield possibly?



The biggest problem the army ran into was the fact that there were far too few soldiers trained to operate and maintain them.



Walter Davidson, president of Harley-Davidson worked closely with the War Department to not only supply motorcycles but to also train soldiers how to drive and maintain them. His concept was to recruit men who were already familiar with the machines and the knowledge of how they worked?

Walter said - quote:

"I am firmly of the belief that the best way is for Congress to authorize the army to recruit civilians with special training and obtain them quickly through the attraction of a short enlistment with promise of immediate service in the work of dispersing Villa's bandits in Mexico." (Walter Davidson, wire service report, April, 1916)

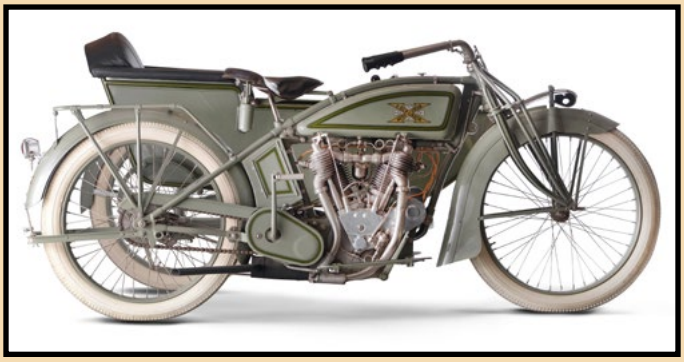
In 1917, when the US entered World War I, the War Department urgently sought reliable motorcycles from major American manufactures, focusing heavily on the 1917 Indian powerplus and the Harley-Davidson Model J often equipped with sidecars. These along with Excelsior motorcycles, were tested to meet the demand for thousands of machines for the war effort.



Indian Power Plus



Harley-Davidson J Model



1917 Excelsior Model 17

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Soldiers testing the Excelsior

Harley-Davidson won the contract to produce 20,000 model 17s and 18s consuming half of Harley-Davidson's production for those years. The biggest reason the War Department chose H-D was the willingness of H-D to support the military as Walter Davidson had envisioned earlier. Harley-Davidson established the School for Motorcycle Mechanics in Milwaukee in 1917. The school was created to train military recruits the mechanical skills needed to maintain motorcycles in combat situations.









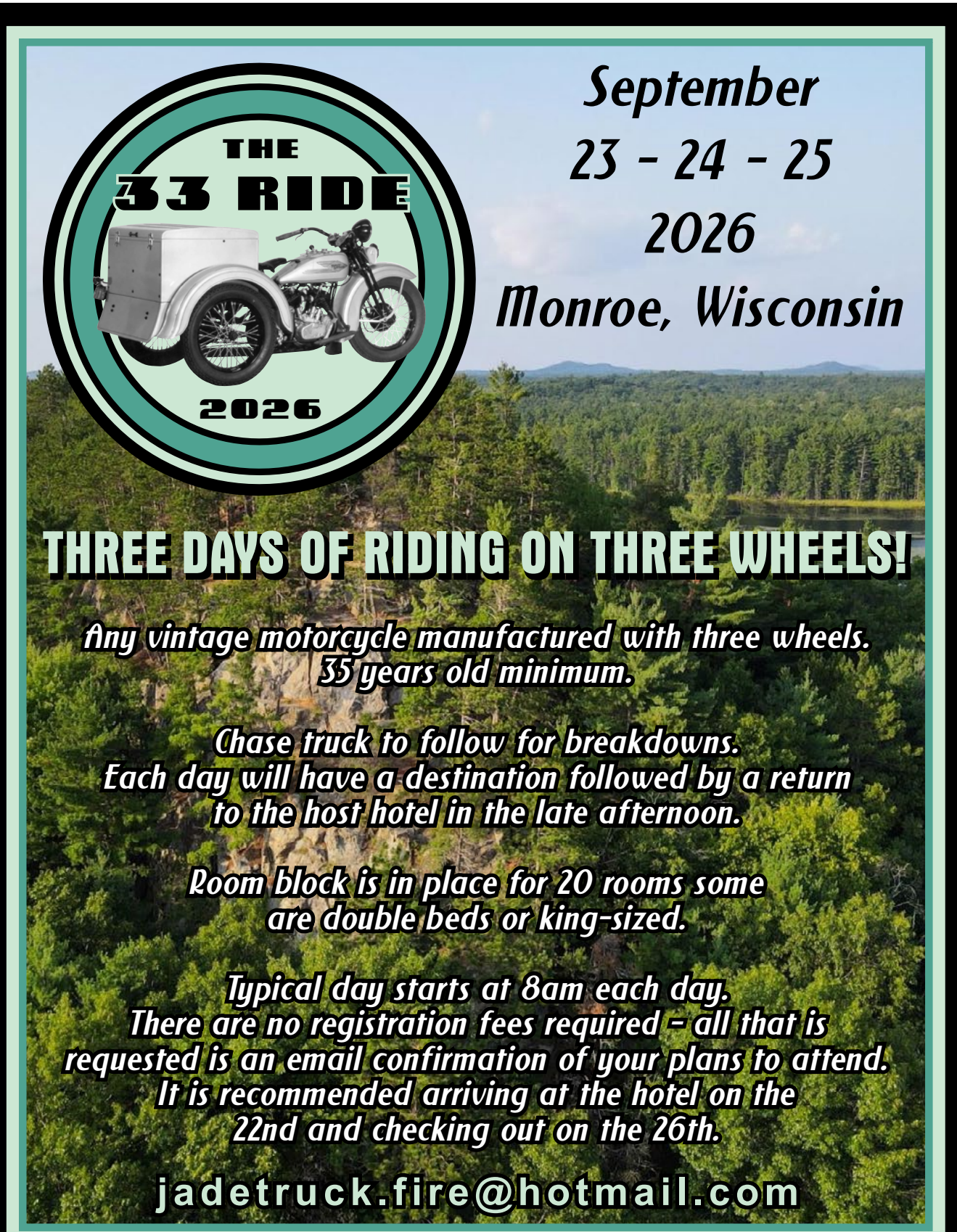
Recruits were trained to maintain and repair engines, mechanics, electrical systems and frame issues. The course was three weeks long.

Along with training came the issuance of specialized tools used specifically for H-D motorcycles, note tools hung on the walls.

To be continued...

Matt Miller


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Spokesman Stories

Calling All Members!

I am always looking for more content for the Spokesman newsletter.

I know many of you attend various events and take photos and have a story to tell. I see the photos on Facebook all the time and just wish you could send at least a dozen of those photos to me with a short story about the event. We would all like to see and hear what our memebers are doing.

I will no longer ask individuals for photos and a story as I would like to leave it up to them if they choose to send anything or not.

If you need help with your story I can help and will always do a punctuation and spell check of the stories and may edit them a little as well.

Thanks! Newsletter Editor - Steve Peters

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